

Validating Round-Up Investing

A feature brief handed over the way a real leader hands one over: round up every UPI payment to the next ₹10, quietly invest the spare change. This is how I'd find out whether it deserves to exist — before anyone writes a line of code.

SCOPE

Feature opportunity validation

STATUS

Plan, not a completed study

The brief

A consumer wealth-and-payments app in India — UPI plus investing, roughly 8M monthly active users, mostly aged 22 upward. The proposal: every UPI payment rounds up to the next ₹10, and the spare change is quietly invested into a low-risk fund. Leadership's hypothesis is that this becomes a low-friction bridge into investing for daily payment users who never start on their own.

What the brief did not specify: **who exactly this is for, how big the problem really is, what people do today instead, and what “moves our numbers” means.** Those four gaps are the entire job. Everything below exists to close them before the engineering budget gets committed.

The reframe the brief was missing

Most versions of this feature get justified with “users want to save more.” That is a wish, not a mechanism — and a feature built on a wish has nothing to falsify. The sharper reading is behavioural:

The informal “spare change” savings habit people had with cash has no equivalent in a UPI-first world — and UPI's frictionlessness removes the natural pause that used to prompt saving. Both the old mechanism and the old cue are gone.

That changes what the feature's job actually is. It is not an investing product. It is a **cue-replacement mechanism** — rebuilding a trigger that digital payments quietly destroyed. Which is why the thing to test is effortlessness, not returns, and why investment literacy is explicitly out of scope.

Part A — Manager briefing

Three claims, each written so it could be proven wrong. Nobody talks to a user until these exist.

STRATEGIC FIT

Mission, tightened to this feature: shatter the psychological barriers to saving and investing, building healthy everyday habits through automated micro-savings in low-risk funds.

The bet is a transition — from small-scale micro-savings behaviour into full-scale investing engagement — by building trust and transparency first. **What I'd own:** activation and adoption of the payments-to-investing bridge. Specifically the percentage of eligible payment users who have never invested and opt in, and the percentage still actively rounding up at 30, 60 and 90 days.

USER VALUE

Profile: urban professionals, 26–32, metro and Tier-1 cities, earning ₹40–80k a month. Mid-career, with enough disposable income to feel the absence of a savings habit, but not yet investing. They use the app for small, frequent daily UPI payments — food, transport, chai — rather than big-ticket transactions, so non-round amounts occur several times a day and the round-up mechanism gets constant, near-invisible trigger points.

Problem: two-part. The cash-era spare-change habit has no UPI equivalent, and UPI's frictionlessness removed the pause that prompted saving. It surfaces as RDs and SIPs set up once and quietly abandoned after a month or two.

Severity: this is the part that decides whether the feature is worth building. Users express genuine guilt and anxiety about not saving — tied to feeling like they are failing at a basic adult responsibility. That makes it a values problem, not a minor inconvenience, and values problems sustain behaviour change.

Goal: the user feels they built a savings habit without having to think about it or manage anything — unlike a manual SIP, which demands ongoing attention they have already proven they won't give.

BUSINESS VALUE

Users build initial trust in the investing product through a low-stakes, no-decision entry point, which makes them receptive to higher-value products later. Expected 30–40% of the never-invested segment opting in within the first quarter, plus improved 90-day retention among opted-in users from the switching-cost effect of an active, growing balance sitting in the app.

Explicitly not: a user-acquisition play. This is for the existing 8M base, not a marketing hook to bring in new users. And not an investment-education product — the feature is a behavioural nudge into a low-risk default fund.

Stakeholders this touches

Compliance and legal, because it is a regulated investment product with auto-debit consent. Finance, for fund flow and commission structure. Then customer support, who will field every question about deductions and fund performance; the investing product team, who own the underlying fund; and marketing, for launch messaging.

Part B — Six users, and how to reach them

Six completed interviews, recruited honestly rather than optimistically. Working backwards through the funnel — 75% show-up, 30% screener completion, 10% passing screening — roughly **268 people must register interest**, split across two channels, with a ₹500 voucher per completed interview.

The six are defined behaviourally, not demographically:

- **The good-intentions guy** — has a lapsed SIP he set up once and forgot. His habit died from neglect, not disinterest.
- **The over-analyser** — tracks expenses obsessively in a spreadsheet but never acts on the insights. All the data, no behavioural follow-through.
- **The serial-starter** — has tried three investing apps and abandoned all of them, proving access isn't the blocker.
- **The avoider** — actively won't open the investments tab out of anxiety. Investing feels intimidating, not merely inconvenient.
- **The rupee-precise dad** — 50–65k, married with a young kid, splits every bill over UPI, hyper-aware of every rupee owed, and still has no savings buffer.
- **The impulse-spender** — treats herself right after salary credit and regrets it later. Testing whether round-up can save her from herself.

Screening for the behaviour, not the opinion

- Have you set up a recurring deposit, SIP, or savings goal in the last year that you later stopped contributing to?
- Do you currently use any method — an app, spreadsheet, or manual habit — to track or set aside spare money after a purchase?
- How do you typically feel when you open the investments section of a financial app — comfortable, or something you tend to avoid?

The staged interview guide

Roughly five minutes building psychological safety, ten immersing in context, then thirty on real validation questions.

HOW THE SESSION OPENS

"Before we start, just so you know — I'm not from the investing team, I'm just trying to learn how people actually manage money day to day. There's no right or wrong answer here, and you genuinely can't hurt my feelings. It's not my project, I'm here to learn."

That disclaimer is doing real work. Every persona here carries some guilt about money. If the interviewer reads as an owner of the thing being discussed, the answers turn into performance.

Every validation question anchors to a specific past event rather than a hypothetical — because what people say they would do and what they did are different data:

- Walk me through the last time you got your salary — what did you do with it in the first few days?
- Think about the last UPI payment you made today or yesterday — what were you paying for, and how much was it?
- Walk me through the last time you set up a recurring deposit or SIP — what happened over the following weeks?
- Tell me about the last time you spent on something small and had leftover change. What did you do with it?
- Walk me through the last time you had a small amount of money sitting idle in your account — what happened to it eventually?

Questions I wrote, then rejected

Interview quality is mostly a function of what you refuse to ask. Three that did not survive my own review:

"Think about the last time someone suggested an investment app or product to you..."

Assumes the event occurred. Not open or behaviour-safe for every respondent.

"Tell me about the last time you felt behind on saving compared to your friends or peers..."

Leading. Embeds an assumption of peer comparison and of feeling "behind."

"...a time you opened an investing app but didn't go through with putting money in"

Double-barrelled. Opening the app and what stopped them are two separate probes.

Part C — Why an interview alone isn't enough

These users are immersed in payments but not in investing. Several personas show active avoidance, or a history of abandoning investment products. Asking them to *imagine* round-up investing risks a socially desirable answer rather than a real reaction — they have no existing mental model for this mechanism and cannot reliably self-report on it.

The hypothesis is genuinely unproven rather than merely untested, and this is pre-build validation with time to do it properly. So the plan pairs both methods. The interview surfaces the *why* behind past behaviour — why the SIP lapsed, why they avoid the tab. The design method tests reaction to the mechanism itself.

THE THREE KNOBS, AND A DELIBERATE ADAPTATION

Method: give reasons for their actions, structured as "use it silently first, then explain."

Stimulus: a vibe-prototyped, clickable opt-in flow — toggle, plain-language explanation, confirmation.

Moderator role: silent observer during the task, active probe immediately after. This is **not a stock pairing** — it is adapted for persona four's anxiety profile, where real-time probing would contaminate the natural reaction.

What the stimulus includes, and what it deliberately doesn't

In: the in-app notification introducing Round-Up Investing, the opt-in screen with its toggle and plain-language explanation ("pay ₹47, ₹3 gets invested"), and the confirmation immediately after toggling on.

Out: the post-payment congratulations message and the full savings dashboard. Both are real parts of the feature. Both test a different hypothesis — whether reward messaging and progress-tracking drive retention — which is itself unvalidated and risks being annoying rather than motivating. Including them would muddy the signal on the one decision that matters most here:

Does the opt-in itself trigger investing-anxiety, or does effortlessness hold?

It has to be a real clickable flow rather than a static wireframe. A full vibe-coded product with backend logic isn't justified at this stage, but a hand-drawn wireframe wouldn't be convincing enough for genuine hesitation to surface — and hesitation is the finding.

HOLDING THE ROLE CONSISTENTLY

Stay silent and avoid reacting, verbally or facially, while the participant navigates the flow — resisting the urge to clarify or help even when they hesitate. The moment they finish, opt out, or give up, switch into active probing and walk back through specific moments using their own path as the prompt: *“I noticed you paused right here — what was going through your mind?”*

Part D — Synthesis, and what would make me wrong

The synthesis sheets are built and deliberately empty, waiting on findings. Each hypothesis resolves to one of three outcomes — **supports, contradicts, or new finding** — with HYP04 tested via both methods so the interview and the design session can disagree with each other. The final decision is one of three: proceed to refine business value, gather more user validation, or invalidate and take it back to my manager.

~268

registrations needed for 6 interviews

₹270–750

monthly accumulation at 90–150 transactions

40–60%

of 8M MAU assumed never-invested

That last figure is the one to attack first, and I want to be precise about its status: **it is an educated guess from immersion, not measured data.** It is the first thing I'd check against internal numbers, and if it comes back materially lower, the business case weakens before a single interview gets scheduled.

The economics are modest by design. At 90–150 UPI transactions a month, a user accumulates roughly ₹3,240–9,000 a year before returns. Small individually — but the goal is habit formation over months and years, not a large first-year corpus. If the research shows users judge it on corpus size rather than effortlessness, the framing is wrong and the feature needs rethinking.

This is a plan, not a study. I did not run these interviews. What it demonstrates is how I'd spend a research budget — and, more usefully, what I'd refuse to spend it on.